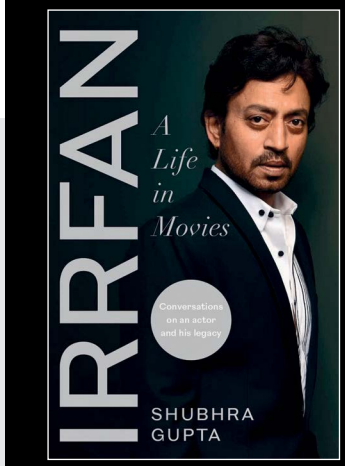
BOOKS

PORTRAIT OF A STAR

SHUBHRA GUPTA'S ***IRRFAN: A LIFE IN MOVIES*** IS A COLLECTION OF CONVERSATIONS WITH IRRFAN KHAN'S CLOSE ASSOCIATES



IRRFAN
A Life in Movies
by Shubhra Gupta
PAN MACMILLAN
₹899; 408 pages

Not long before Irrfan Khan's death from cancer in 2020, Naseeruddin Shah received a message from him saying "Knock, knock, Naseer bhai". Shah promptly rang him to ask how he was feeling. After a diversionary chat, Irrfan spoke words that moved Shah deeply: "*Ab kya karein*, how many people have the opportunity to see death approaching?...I wanted to do more with my life, but never got the chance. I don't hold that against fate."

Gone at 53 at the height of his powers, Irrfan's trajectory was relatively short, of about 20 years. But the boy from a small town near Jaipur who worked the mill, like many others, of a National School of Drama degree followed by mostly indifferent TV serials, made an outstanding impact on filmgoers at home and abroad, with performances ranging from the murderous gangster in *Maqbool* (2004), Vishal Bhardwaj's take on *Macbeth*, to the heart-wrenching journey of an immigrant's life packed into Mira Nair's *The Namesake* (2006) or the piercing authenticity of the biopic of the athlete-turned-soldier-turned-outlaw in his college mate Tigmanshu Dhulia's *Paan Singh Tomar* (2012).

GUPTA UNDERSCORES IRRFAN'S VALUE AS A DISRUPTOR IN A MAINSTREAM INDUSTRY WHERE THE BOX OFFICE CREATES AND DISCARDS STARS

Film critic Shubhra Gupta's book on Irrfan (who dropped his last name 'Khan' mid-career possibly to emphasise his distinct identity from the Bollywood tribe of Khans) is neither a comprehensive biography nor a critical appraisal of the actor. Rather it's a series of over 30 interviews with Irrfan's directors, co-actors, family and friends that—despite a few omissions, such as his major co-star Tabu or the award-winning Asif Kapadia, who cast him in *The Warrior* (2001) that brought him early recognition—add up to a compelling portrait of the actor's unwavering pursuit of a path uniquely his own.

His looks set him apart. Spotting him at a drama school rehearsal in the 1980s, Mira Nair was struck by his "hooded-eyed, quiet, intense way...his preying-mantis looks". Fifteen years later, there was no one else—"no audition, nothing"—who could play Ashoke Ganguly in *The Namesake*. Watching him in a trial viewing, Vishal Bhardwaj exclaimed, "*Yeh hai Maqbool* (this is Maqbool)." With guileless candour, Karan Johar confesses he "never had a screenplay, a film, a thought or an idea that would warrant the presence...that Irrfan Khan brought to the table."

Johar's wish for an Irrfan

BOOKS

THOSE WERE THE **DAYS**

***Avijit Ghosh**'s ode to 1980s Hindi cinema reassesses an unfairly maligned decade that was more dynamic than we realise*

Movie buffs of a certain vintage, this reviewer included, have often decried the 1980s as the unquestioned nadir for Hindi cinema. The only redeeming thing about that decade, we have declared, were the 'art' or 'parallel' films made by directors like Shyam Benegal, Govind Nihalani and Ketan Mehta—even if those were sometimes just as trite as the commercial films (and even if the parallel star-system headlined by Shabana Azmi and Naseeruddin Shah, Om Puri and Smita Patil, could be as much of a closed echo-chamber as the mainstream star system). However, there comes a point in the life of any serious cineaste when one can look back on even disreputable decades through a lens that combines nostalgia with serious analysis, allowing us to recognise the good things amidst the dreck, and the many ways in which our lives were transformed by both. With that in mind, Avijit Ghosh's affectionate revisiting of the 1980s is a good addition to our popular-film literature.

Ghosh begins, in a short prelude or 'trailer', by making a few defining statements ("The Eighties was a time of disruption and change in Hindi cinema", "The Eighties acted as a hyphen between the past and the future") and then elaborates on these by offering sociological